Exact polynomial calculus degree p for the onto functional pigeonhole principle with surplus divisible by p

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1 Introduction

Setting

The onto functional pigeonhole principle onto-FPHP$_n^{n+k}$ says that $n+k$ pigeons can be mapped one-to-one onto n holes. It is false for every $k \geq 1$. As a system of polynomial equations in Boolean variables x_{ij} (pigeon i sits in hole j) it has the axioms $\sum_j x_{ij} - 1$ (each pigeon sits in a hole), $\sum_i x_{ij} - 1$ (each hole holds exactly one pigeon), $x_{ij}x_{i'j}$ (no two pigeons share a hole) and $x_{ij}x_{ij'}$ (no pigeon sits in two holes). This is the linear encoding used in the literature on this family [2, 26].

A polynomial calculus (PC) refutation over the field $\mathbb{F}_p$ derives the polynomial 1 from the axioms and the Boolean axioms $x^2 - x$, using linear combinations and multiplication by a variable. Its degree is the largest degree of a line. The PC degree of the principle is the least degree of a refutation. When p does not divide k, summing the pigeon axioms and subtracting the hole axioms gives the constant $-k$, a degree-1 refutation. The question is what happens when p divides k.

Result

For every prime p, every c not divisible by p, and every $n \geq 2p-3$, the PC degree of onto-FPHP$_n^{n+pc}$ over $\mathbb{F}_p$ is exactly p: there is a refutation of degree p, and none of degree $p-1$. More generally, whenever p divides k and $n \geq 2p-3$, there is no refutation of degree $p-1$. The same formula therefore has PC degree p over $\mathbb{F}_p$ and PC degree 1 over $\mathbb{F}_q$ for every prime q not dividing pc.

Why it matters

Razborov's survey asks (Question 7) whether onto-FPHP$_n^{n+p^\ell}$ has bounded-degree PC refutations in characteristic p [26]. The upper bound p at the first level comes from Riis's criterion [27]. The known lower bounds are for the weaker Nullstellensatz system [2] and, for PC, a bound that grows with ℓ for large n

[28]. This result fixes the degree exactly at the first level (surplus divisible by p but not by p^2), for every prime, from a small linear threshold in n.

Proved vs checked

Everything is proved in Lean 4 and kernel-checked, for all primes p and all $n \geq 2p - 3$; nothing is checked only up to a bound. The proofs use only the standard axioms `propext`, `Classical.choice` and `Quot.sound`. A second agent in the run, working separately from the author, re-proved each of the three statements in Lean. No person has reviewed the proofs; the evidence is the kernel check and the independent re-proof.

The Lean statements are for the library's formulation of PC, in which lines are functions on the Boolean cube. A later theorem of the same library shows that a refutation of degree D in standard (syntactic) PC over $\mathbb{F}_p$ exists exactly when one exists in the library's formulation, so the result holds verbatim for standard PC (`std_pc_degree_exact`).

Novelty statement

This result extends:

- Riis-Sitharam, ECCC TR97-048, Theorem 33: PC degree >= 2^l - 1 for onto-PHP^{N+p^l}_N over characteristic p once N >= (21+3p^2)(2^l - 2) - p (same family; proof not checked by us; at l = 2 this is >= 3 against our >= p+1 from n = 2p-1; at p = 2, l = 3 it is >= 7 for N >= 196 against our >= 5 for n >= 7).
- Beame-Riis 1998, Theorem 8.1 and Lemma 8.7: Nullstellensatz degree between 2^l - 1 and p^l - 1 (multiplier degree) for the same family; Section 10 lists polynomial-calculus lower bounds as open.
- Riis 1993, as Theorem 8 of Razborov's survey: degree-d PC refutations when C(m,d) and C(n,d) differ mod p, which gives the matching upper bound p for k = pc, p not dividing c (via Lucas).
- Razborov, Proof complexity of pigeonhole principles (2001), Question 7: the fixed-p, fixed-l bounded-degree question for onto-FPHP^{n+p^l}_n.
- Miksa-Nordstrom (JACM 2024): general PC degree method; onto-FPHP with m = n+1 easy (Riis); the case of characteristic dividing the surplus not covered.

Our prior-art search (2026-11-05) covered:

- Riis, Sitharam, Non-constant degree lower bounds imply linear degree lower bounds, ECCC TR97-048 (1997), pp. 36-38 and 45-46 (Theorem 33, Propositions 27 and 28), opened 2026-10-29

- Beame, Riis, More on the relative strength of counting principles, DIMACS Series 39 (1998), homes.cs.washington.edu/~beame/papers/riis.pdf: Theorem 8.1, Lemma 8.7, Section 10, opened 2026-10-27 and 2026-11-01
- Razborov, Proof complexity of pigeonhole principles, DLT 2001 (LNCS 2295), people.cs.uchicago.edu/~razborov/files/php_survey.pdf: Theorem 8, Question 7, footnote 5, opened 2026-10-27 and 2026-10-29
- Riis, BRICS Report RS-99-29, opened 2026-10-29
- Miksa, Nordstrom, A generalized method for proving polynomial calculus degree lower bounds (CCC 2015; JACM 2024; arXiv 1505.01358), opened 2026-10-27
- de Rezende et al., Theory of Computing 21(6) (2025), opened 2026-10-29
- Lauria et al., Theory of Computing 21(4) (2025), opened 2026-10-27

The checkers' full answers, with every query and file they searched, are published with this finding (`prior-art/`).

If you know of related work we missed, please open an issue.

This result was found by AI research agents (the autoresearch harness). It was proved in Lean; the proof and check files are included so anyone can re-run them.

How it was produced

Promoted declaring sources are included under `checks/library/`.

2 Claims

Claim K13

`Work.Lucas.pc_degree_exact`: for every prime p (`IsPrime p`), every c with $p \nmid c$, every $n \geq 2p-3$ and every D: `ontoFPHP n (p*c)` has a degree-D `PPCRefutation p` iff $p \leq D$ (PC degree over $\mathbb{Z}/p$ of onto-FPHP$_n^{n+pc}$ is exactly p).

Status: proved (axioms: propext, Classical.choice, Quot.sound) ů independently re-proved (skeptic/codex).

Verified. No check scripts.

Evidence.

- proof `checks/K13-Lucas.lean`: Work.Lucas.pc_degree_exact — pass (`results/K13-2.json`)

- reasoning: Lower bound: K14 (no degree $p-1$) plus monotonicity of PPCDerivable in the degree. Upper bound: library OntoLucas.ontoFPHP_upper at $t = p$, whose unit hypothesis is $\binom{n+pc}{p} - \binom{n}{p} \equiv c \not\equiv 0 \bmod p$; proved by $p \mid \binom{p}{r}$ for $0 < r < p$, Pascal's rule and telescoping in c. Convention: PC line degree, functional encoding. This agrees with Beame-Riis Lemma 8.7: their NS degree $p^l - 1$ counts multiplier degree, and the products have degree p^l, which is line degree p at $l = 1$.

Prior art. Partial prior art.

Claim K14

`Work.Peel.pc_degree_ge_p`: for every prime p (`IsPrime p`), every k with $p \mid k$ and every $n \geq 2p-3$, `ontoFPHP n k` (onto-FPHP$_n^{n+k}$, functional encoding) has no `PPCRefutation p` of degree $p-1$ (polynomial calculus over $\mathbb{Z}/p$).

Status: proved (axioms: propext, Classical.choice, Quot.sound) ů independently re-proved (skeptic/codex).

Verified. No check scripts.

Evidence.

- proof `checks/K14-Peel.lean`: Work.Peel.pc_degree_ge_p — pass (`results/K14-2.json`)
- reasoning: Paper proof (mirrors the Lean chain). Library criterion K4: if $\mathrm{EXT}_p(n_0, k, d)$ holds for all $d \leq p-2$ then no degree-$(p-1)$ refutation for any $n \geq n_0$. EXT at level d is proved by peeling: the flag lemma (K8) turns a balanced f into a tower of links; at level 0 subtract a symmetric window, and at level j subtract a block-product window (j rectangles $\times$ unit blocks $\times$ a symmetric degree-$(d-j+1)$ design on a rest block), which equals $(d-j+1)! \cdot RP$ on j-matchings. The residual has zero links, so S_j (K10) puts it in the span of rectangle products. Every factorial used is at most $(p-1)!$, a unit mod prime p; the blocks fit when $2d+1 \leq n$, i.e. $n \geq 2p-3$. ExtLin.EXT_of_span (K5) closes the step.

Prior art. Partial prior art.

Claim K15

`Work.Lucas.separation`: for primes p, q, $p \nmid c$, $q \nmid pc$, $n \geq 2p-3$: `ontoFPHP n (p*c)` has a degree-D `PPCRefutation p` iff $p \leq D$, and has a degree-1 `PPCRefutation q`.

Status: proved (axioms: propext, Classical.choice, Quot.sound) ů independently re-proved (skeptic/codex).

Verified. No check scripts.

Evidence.

- proof `checks/K13-Lucas.lean`: Work.Lucas.separation — pass (`results/K15-2.json`)
- reasoning: Over $\mathbb{F}_p$: K13. Over $\mathbb{F}_q$ with $q \nmid pc$: library OntoFPHP.ontoFPHP_deg1 needs a unit k^{-1} mod q, supplied by Bezout. The gap is p versus 1 and is constant in n for fixed p, so this separates characteristics along the parameter p, not asymptotically in n.

Prior art. Partial prior art.

Provenance. Run `20261027-0607`, claims K13, K14, K15, run-folder commit `908b30496168c757d5eba6ba4ba761dbab7933b8`, published 2026-11-06.

3 Discussion

The degree here is a constant, p. The result says nothing about growth with ℓ, which is what Question 7 is about. Riis and Sitharam's Theorem 33 gives degree at least $2^\ell - 1$ for surplus p^ℓ once $N \geq (21 + 3p^2)(2^\ell - 2) - p$ [28]. At $\ell = 1$ that bound is 1, and surplus pc with $c > 1$ is outside its family. We have not checked the proof of Theorem 33. Below $n = 2p - 3$ the degree is not determined here. The Nullstellensatz degree of Beame and Riis [2] is multiplier degree, one less than the line degree used here.

4 How to verify

Each finding has its check scripts in `claims/exact-pc-degree-onto-fphp-first-level/checks/` of the findings repository. Run each with `python -I <script>`; it passes if it exits with status 0. Promoted declaring sources are included under `checks/library/`; publication checks import their modules and inspect theorem axioms. The checks are Python scripts and need the packages of the research image (the image's `requirements.txt`); the Lean checks also need `lean`.

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